

Chapter 05: Maturation

Brief Summary

This chapter argues that adult development continues long after adolescence and that personality is not simply fixed by age thirty. Vaillant uses Erik Erikson's theory of adult development but revises it using Grant Study data. He treats adult growth as the mastery of developmental tasks rather than neat stages. The major tasks include Identity, Intimacy, Career Consolidation, Generativity, Guardianship, and Integrity. The chapter is about what it means to grow up across a whole life, not merely to get older.

Key Study Findings

- Success in love and work at one time did not reliably remain stable. Only a small number of men who were top adjusted at midlife stayed top adjusted across later ratings, so maturation cannot be reduced to early adult achievement.
- Erikson's model fits the data better when treated as flexible developmental tasks rather than fixed stages.
- Identity means separating psychologically, socially, economically, and ideologically from one's family of origin while retaining useful identifications.
- Intimacy means the capacity for sustained, emotionally attached, interdependent commitment. Marriage is one possible indicator but not the whole concept.
- Career Consolidation is Vaillant's addition: a career requires commitment, competence, compensation or social value, and contentment. Prestige alone does not make work developmentally mature.
- Generativity means sustained responsibility for guiding the next generation beyond one's own children. It is a shift from self-absorption toward care for others' growth.
- Guardianship means preserving and transmitting culture, memory, values, and institutions for the future. Its shadow is hoarding or preservation for its own sake.
- Generativity was strongly associated with longevity and joy. In 2011, only 4 of 31 men who failed to mature beyond Intimacy were alive, compared with 50 of 128 who reached Generativity.
- Generative men lived about eight years longer on average than men who never mastered Career Consolidation.
- Maturation can be disrupted by alcoholism, depression, dementia, brain injury, and social loss. Aging alone does not guarantee growth.

Interesting Stories And Examples

- Charles Boatwright demonstrates positive maturation through the tasks of love, work, responsibility, and late-life integrity.
- Peter Penn is a painful example of developmental arrest. He worked hard, stayed married, and avoided obvious vice, yet never achieved real intimacy, purpose, or joy.
- Bill DiMaggio, from the Inner City cohort, shows that measured IQ and class are not destiny. He becomes responsible, humorous, protective, and generative through work, union leadership, marriage, and parenting.
- Algernon Young shows that privilege and even early love are not enough if later fear prevents internalization. His life narrows around safety, things, and avoidance until a partial late-life reconnection through church and marriage.

Why It Matters

The chapter makes adult development morally and clinically serious. Failure to mature is not just a different lifestyle; in Vaillant's data it is associated with loneliness, poor adjustment, less joy, and shorter life.